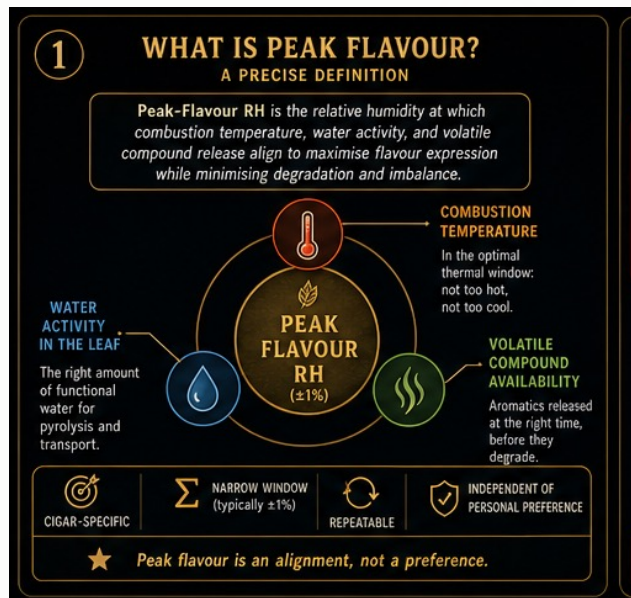


The Peak-Flavour Framework

Module purpose · moving from preference to performance diagnosis

Module 3 objective



- Define Peak-Flavour RH accurately.
- Explain why small RH changes can alter flavour dramatically.
- Distinguish flavour balance from strength, smoothness or aroma intensity.
- Predict failure modes above and below peak RH.
- Apply the framework professionally across different constructions.

This module explains when a cigar is performing correctly and why.



Module 3 learning map

What this module covers

FOUNDATIONS

- Understanding Peak-Flavour RH
- The Peak-Flavour Alignment Model
- Why the window is narrow
- Peak flavour vs perceived quality
- Failure modes below and above peak RH

APPLICATION

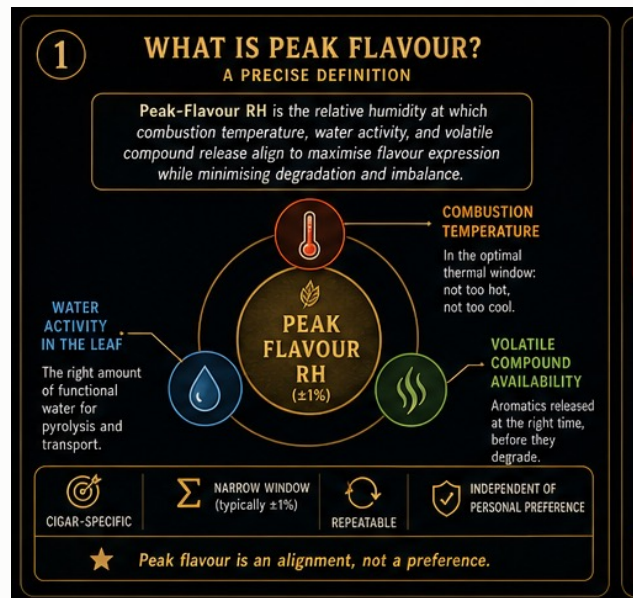
- Assigning peak RH
- Using the framework diagnostically
- Storage RH vs smoking RH
- Peak flavour as a performance system
- Professional scenarios and examination alignment

Candidates should explain performance causally, not simply describe whether they liked the cigar.



What Is Peak-Flavour RH?

A precise definition



Peak-Flavour RH is the RH where

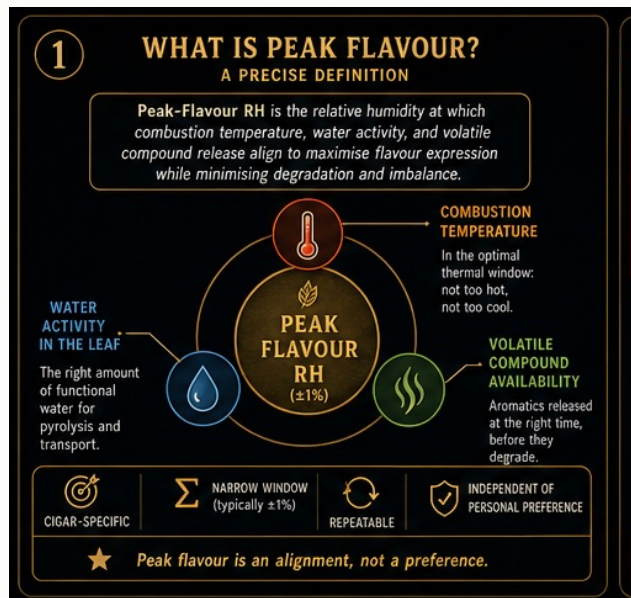
- Combustion temperature, tobacco moisture and flavour-compound release work together most efficiently.
- The cigar delivers optimal sweetness, controlled strength and clean aroma delivery.
- Combustion remains stable and flavour progression stays coherent.
- The range is cigar-specific, narrow, repeatable and measurable through smoking performance.

Peak flavour is an alignment condition, not a personal preference.



What Peak Flavour Is Not

Avoid confusing performance with intensity



Peak flavour does not simply mean

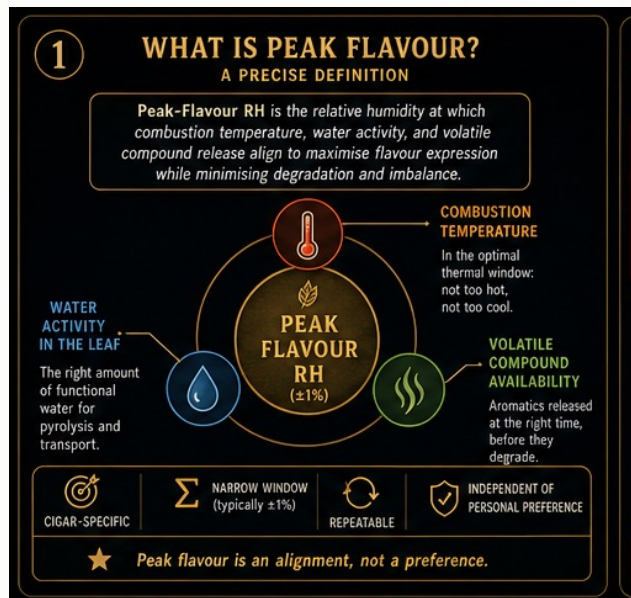
- Maximum strength, maximum smoke output or highest nicotine impact.
- The strongest aroma or the blender's storage recommendation.
- A cigar can feel powerful, smooth or aromatic while still being outside its optimal range.
- The sommelier must identify whether the cigar is operating at its intended flavour balance.

Strength, smoothness and aroma can overlap with peak flavour but they are not the same thing.



Why Peak Flavour Exists

Heat, moisture and volatile release must converge



From previous modules, candidates learned that

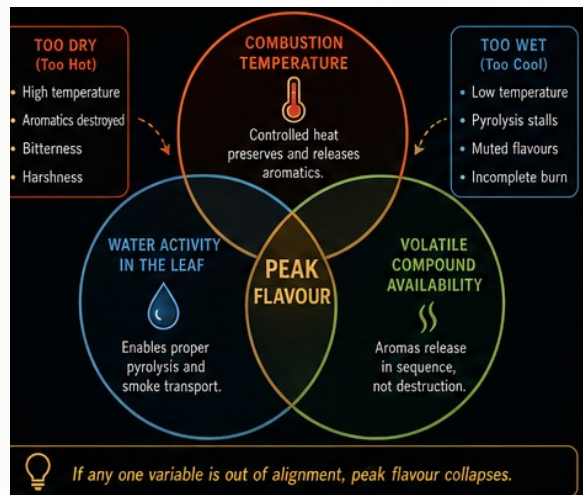
- Combustion occurs within temperature ranges.
- Flavour compounds release at different temperatures.
- Moisture affects combustion speed and tobacco reacts non-linearly to humidity.
- Therefore, there must be a humidity range where heat, moisture and flavour release become properly balanced.

Peak flavour is a combustion and moisture alignment condition.



The Peak-Flavour Alignment Model

Three variables, one outcome



Peak flavour occurs when three variables align

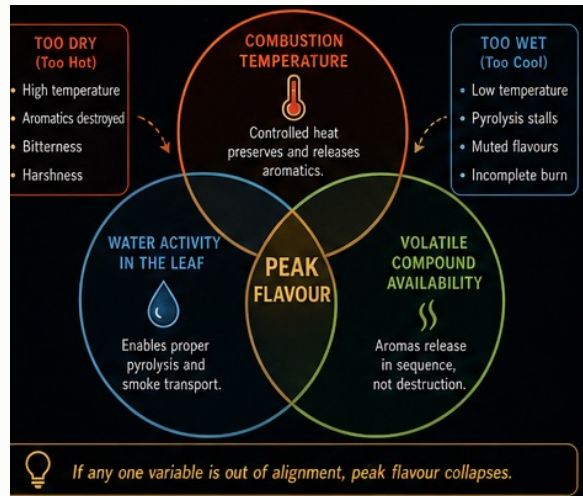
- Combustion temperature: the burn operates within the right thermal window.
- Water activity inside the leaf: functional moisture supports pyrolysis and smoke transport.
- Volatile compound availability: aromas release in sequence without being destroyed.
- If one variable is out of alignment, peak flavour collapses.

The professional diagnoses which variable has moved out of range.



Combustion Temperature Alignment

Too hot and too cool both damage performance



If the cigar is outside the temperature window

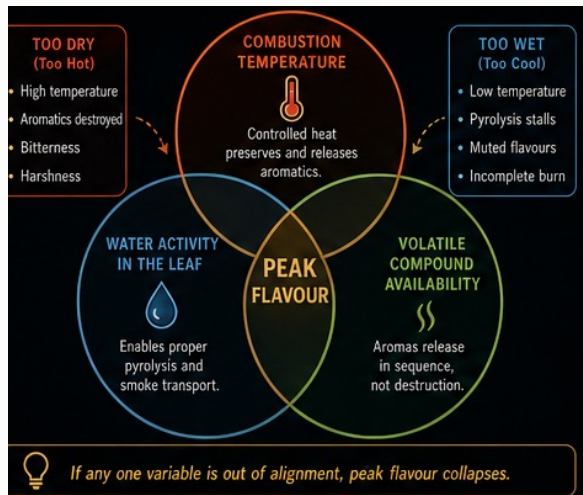
- Too dry: combustion becomes excessively hot, smoke sharpens, sweetness declines and aromatics may burn away.
- Too wet: combustion becomes too cool, flavour release weakens, smoke becomes dull and burn efficiency decreases.
- Peak flavour exists between these two extremes.
- Temperature is managed through RH, moisture condition, construction and smoking cadence.

A cigar does not need the hottest burn; it needs the correct burn.



Water Activity Alignment

Functional moisture governs combustion behaviour



The cigar requires enough functional moisture to

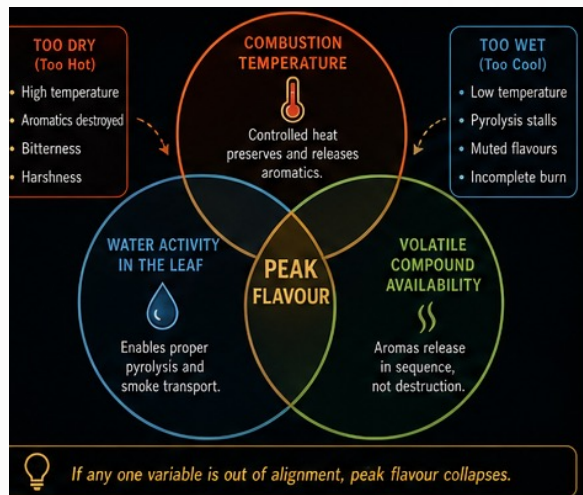
- Regulate combustion and buffer smoke chemistry.
- Support pyrolysis without suppressing it.
- Avoid aggressive sugar carbonization when too dry.
- Avoid sluggish combustion and weak flavour release when too wet.

Professional humidification controls moisture precisely; it does not maximize moisture.



Volatile Compound Release

Humidity controls when aromas appear and survive



Volatile compounds release differently

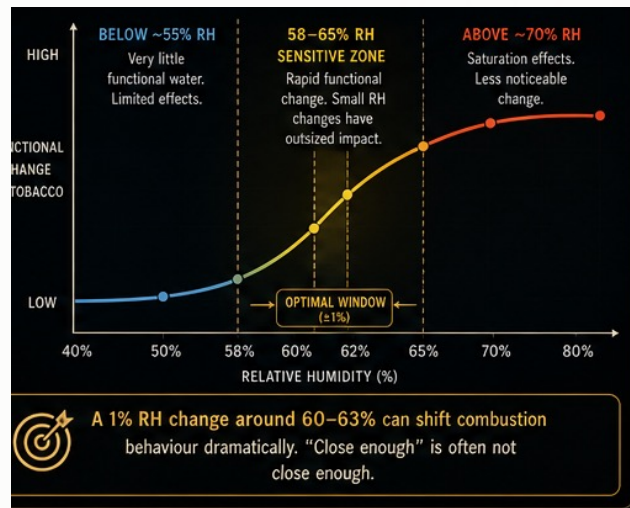
- Some compounds vaporize easily; others require more moderated heat.
- Humidity affects when compounds release, how long they survive and whether they degrade before reaching the smoker.
- This changes sweetness, aroma clarity, spice balance, smoke texture and flavour complexity.
- Poor RH alignment can make a good cigar taste incomplete or distorted.

Humidity changes flavour because it changes combustion and volatile release.



Why the Peak-Flavour Window Is Narrow

Non-linear tobacco response



Tobacco does not respond linearly to RH

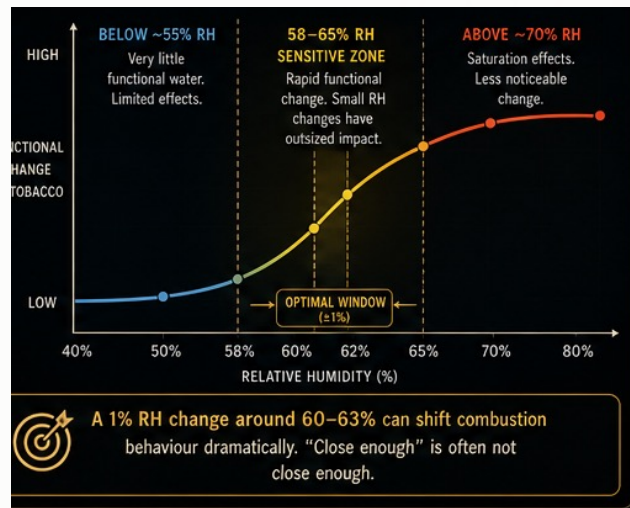
- Within normal smoking ranges, small RH adjustments can significantly alter combustion temperature.
- They can also alter smoke texture, flavour release and nicotine delivery.
- A cigar at 62% RH may perform very differently from the same cigar at 65% RH.
- Professionally, "close enough" is often not precise enough.

A 1% RH change around 60-63% can shift combustion behaviour dramatically.



Why $\pm 1\%$ RH Matters

Precision matters more than average humidity



Within approximately $\pm 1\%$ of peak RH

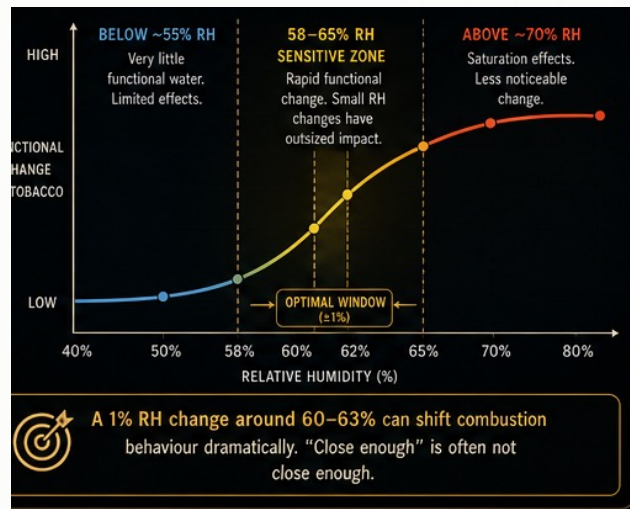
- Combustion usually remains controlled.
- Flavour remains balanced and degradation occurs gradually.
- Outside this range, imbalance accelerates.
- Flavour distortion increases and combustion efficiency can decline rapidly.

Peak flavour is managed through precision, not broad humidity habit.



Common Student Mistake

One storage range does not fit every cigar



Incorrect assumption

- “Any cigar stored between 65–72% RH should smoke the same.”
- This is incorrect because different cigars respond differently to moisture.
- They also burn differently and reach peak flavour at different RH levels.
- The sommelier must evaluate the cigar’s architecture, not rely on a generic storage number.

Universal RH thinking is the opposite of professional Peak-Flavor management.



Peak Flavour vs Perceived Quality

Understanding the difference

Many smokers confuse quality with

TOO DRY Feels Stronger	PEAK FLAVOUR Balanced & Complete	TOO WET Feels Smoother
 ✗ Burns hotter ✗ Nicotine spikes ✗ Sharp, peppery ✗ Bitterness ✗ Sweetness collapses NOT PEAK FLAVOUR	 ✓ Temperature in range ✓ Aromas preserved ✓ Sweetness present ✓ Body and strength balanced ✓ Evolves across the smoke THIS IS PEAK FLAVOUR	 ✗ Burns cooler ✗ Muted aroma ✗ Dull flavours ✗ Uneven or sluggish burn ✗ Lacks clarity NOT PEAK FLAVOUR



Strength is intensity. Smoothness is softness.
Peak flavour is balance, clarity, and harmony.

- Strength, smoothness or smoke density.
- A sommelier evaluates balance, combustion behaviour, flavour clarity and progression instead.
- A cigar can feel strong because it is overheating.
- A cigar can feel smooth because it is over-humidified and under-performing.

Peak flavour is balance, clarity and harmony — not intensity alone.



Why Dry Cigars Feel Stronger

Dryness can create a false sense of power

Dry cigars often



- Burn hotter and release nicotine more aggressively.
- Produce sharper smoke and increased pepper sensation.
- Create the illusion of strength, intensity or richness.
- Destroy sweetness, aroma layering and flavour complexity when combustion heat becomes excessive.

Hotter does not mean better.



Why Wet Cigars Feel Smooth

Softness can hide under-performance

TOO DRY Feels Stronger	PEAK FLAVOUR Balanced & Complete	TOO WET Feels Smoother
 ✗ Burns hotter ✗ Nicotine spikes ✗ Sharp, peppery ✗ Bitterness ✗ Sweetness collapses NOT PEAK FLAVOUR	 ✓ Temperature in range ✓ Aromas preserved ✓ Sweetness present ✓ Body and strength balanced ✓ Evolves across the smoke THIS IS PEAK FLAVOUR	 ✗ Burns cooler ✗ Muted aroma ✗ Dull flavours ✗ Uneven or sluggish burn ✗ Lacks clarity NOT PEAK FLAVOUR



Strength is intensity. Smoothness is softness.
Peak flavour is balance, clarity, and harmony.

Over-humidified cigars often

- Burn cooler and feel softer on the palate.
- Suppress harshness temporarily.
- Lose flavour definition, aromatic clarity and combustion efficiency.
- Suppress sweetness expression because pyrolysis becomes incomplete.

Smoothness alone is not peak performance.



The Professional Standard

What peak performance should feel like

Peak flavour is usually identified by



- Balance, controlled combustion and stable flavour transitions.
- Integrated strength and coherent smoke evolution.
- A deliberate, structured and controlled smoking experience.
- The absence of aggressive, muddy or muted performance defects.

The cigar should taste intentional from first light to final third.



Failure Modes Around Peak Flavour

Symptoms, causes and outcomes

The diagnostic logic

TOO DRY (BELOW PEAK)	PEAK FLAVOUR (OPTIMAL)	TOO WET (ABOVE PEAK)
SYMPTOMS (TOO DRY)	AT PEAK (OPTIMAL)	SYMPTOMS (TOO WET)
- Sharp pepper - Bitterness - Hot burn - Nicotine spike - Sweetness collapses	- Aromas expressive - Sweetness balanced - Body present - Strength in control - Clean, even burn	- Muted aroma - Dull sweetness - Muddy flavours - Sluggish / uneven burn - Weak finish
ROOT CAUSE	ROOT CAUSE	ROOT CAUSE
Excessive combustion temperature Aromatics destroyed before proper release.	Temperature, water activity, and volatile release are aligned within the optimal window.	Incomplete pyrolysis Volatile release suppressed Flavour development limited.
Q Cigars passing through peak may taste inconsistent or improve mid-smoke. Diagnosis requires leaf-level measurement, not assumptions.		

- Below peak RH: combustion becomes too aggressive.
- At peak RH: temperature, water activity and volatile release align.
- Above peak RH: combustion becomes too cool and inefficient.
- Cigars passing through equilibrium may taste inconsistent or improve mid-smoke.

Diagnosis requires leaf-level measurement, not assumptions.



Below Peak RH – Too Dry

The cigar is combusting too aggressively

Typical symptoms and likely causes

TOO DRY (BELOW PEAK)	PEAK FLAVOUR (OPTIMAL)	TOO WET (ABOVE PEAK)
SYMPTOMS (TOO DRY) Sharp pepper Bitterness Hot burn Nicotine spike Sweetness collapses	AT PEAK (OPTIMAL) Aromas expressive Sweetness balanced Body present Strength in control Clean, even burn	SYMPTOMS (TOO WET) Muted aroma Dull sweetness Muddy flavours Sluggish / uneven burn Weak finish
ROOT CAUSE Excessive combustion temperature Aromatics destroyed before proper release.	ROOT CAUSE Temperature, water activity, and volatile release are aligned within the optimal window.	ROOT CAUSE Incomplete pyrolysis Volatile release suppressed Flavour development limited.

Cigars passing through peak may taste inconsistent or improve mid-smoke.
 Diagnosis requires leaf-level measurement, not assumptions.

- Sharp pepper → excessive combustion heat.
- Bitterness → sugar degradation.
- Hot smoke → rapid burn rate.
- Harsh nicotine delivery → accelerated volatilization.
- Weak sweetness → aromatic destruction.

Professional interpretation: the cigar is below peak and running too hot.



Above Peak RH — Too Wet

The cigar is combusting too coolly

Typical symptoms and likely causes

TOO DRY (BELOW PEAK)	PEAK FLAVOUR (OPTIMAL)	TOO WET (ABOVE PEAK)
SYMPTOMS (TOO DRY) Sharp pepper Bitterness Hot burn Nicotine spike Sweetness collapses	AT PEAK (OPTIMAL) Aromas expressive Sweetness balanced Body present Strength in control Clean, even burn	SYMPTOMS (TOO WET) Muted aroma Dull sweetness Muddy flavours Sluggish / uneven burn Weak finish
ROOT CAUSE Excessive combustion temperature Aromatics destroyed before proper release.	ROOT CAUSE Temperature, water activity, and volatile release are aligned within the optimal window.	ROOT CAUSE Incomplete pyrolysis Volatile release suppressed Flavour development limited.
Cigars passing through peak may taste inconsistent or improve mid-smoke. Diagnosis requires leaf-level measurement, not assumptions.		

- Muted aroma → suppressed volatilization.
- Flat sweetness → incomplete flavour release.
- Muddy flavours → low combustion efficiency.
- Sluggish burn → excessive moisture load.
- Uneven combustion → incomplete ignition stability.

Professional interpretation: the cigar is above peak and under-performing chemically.



Transitional States

Why performance can change during the smoke

Cigars moving toward equilibrium may

TOO DRY (BELOW PEAK)	PEAK FLAVOUR (OPTIMAL)	TOO WET (ABOVE PEAK)
SYMPTOMS (TOO DRY) 🔥 Sharp pepper 🍋 Bitterness 🔥 Hot burn 🚬 Nicotine spike 🍯 Sweetness collapses	AT PEAK (OPTIMAL) ✅ Aromas expressive ✅ Sweetness balanced ✅ Body present ✅ Strength in control ✅ Clean, even burn	SYMPTOMS (TOO WET) 🌫 Muted aroma 🍯 Dull sweetness 🍯 Muddy flavours 🐢 Sluggish / uneven burn 🏠 Weak finish
ROOT CAUSE Excessive combustion temperature Aromatics destroyed before proper release.	ROOT CAUSE Temperature, water activity, and volatile release are aligned within the optimal window.	ROOT CAUSE Incomplete pyrolysis Volatile release suppressed Flavour development limited.

🔍 Cigars passing through peak may taste inconsistent or improve mid-smoke. Diagnosis requires leaf-level measurement, not assumptions.

- Taste inconsistent across sessions.
- Improve during the smoke as the burn reaches better-equalized zones.
- Behave differently when wrapper and filler have not fully equalized.
- Require controlled storage, acclimatization and accurate RH management before service.

Inconsistent performance is often a settling/equilibration problem.



Applying the Framework Professionally

Predict, diagnose, correct



The professional sequence

- Identify that the cigar is disappointing.
- Decide whether it is above or below peak.
- Check whether the issue is wrapper-led or core-led.
- Confirm whether enough time has passed for equilibration.
- Adjust RH and staging to restore peak performance.

Peak flavour is managed, not guessed.



Assigning Peak RH

Architecture determines the target



Professionals evaluate

- Wrapper thickness and oiliness.
- Filler density and priming selection.
- Fermentation style and blender philosophy.
- Construction factors: shape, cap and density.
- Country of origin alone is not enough to determine optimal smoking RH.

Service decisions must follow cigar architecture.



Using the Framework Diagnostically

Three core questions

When a cigar performs poorly, ask



- Is the cigar above or below peak RH?
- Is the wrapper behaving differently from the filler core?
- Has the cigar fully equilibrated?
- These questions guide corrective action and prevent blame based on brand, factory or preference alone.

Professional analysis stays observational, combustion-based and causally justified.



Storage RH vs Smoking RH

Preservation and performance are not the same objective

The ideal smoking RH may differ from



- Long-term storage RH.
- Shipping RH.
- Retail display RH.
- This is normal: professional cigar management often involves staging, acclimatization and preparation before service.

A cigar can be stored correctly and still not be ready to deliver peak flavour.



Peak Flavour as a Performance System

Context matters

Peak flavour depends on more than humidity alone



- Cigar construction and environmental conditions matter.
- Preparation and staging matter.
- Smoking cadence still matters after RH is correct.
- RH creates the conditions for performance, but technique and equilibration determine delivery.

The sommelier manages a system, not a number.



The Sommelier's Role

Active performance management



The professional sommelier

- Identifies the target RH range.
- Stages the cigar correctly.
- Confirms equilibration before final judgment.
- Guides the smoker appropriately during service.
- Replaces passive storage with active performance management.

The outcome is consistency for the guest and control for the venue.



Scenario 1 – Harsh Smoke

Use the complaint to reason toward the cause

TOO DRY (BELOW PEAK)	PEAK FLAVOUR (OPTIMAL)	TOO WET (ABOVE PEAK)
SYMPTOMS (TOO DRY) Sharp pepper Bitterness Hot burn Nicotine spike Sweetness collapses	AT PEAK (OPTIMAL) Aromas expressive Sweetness balanced Body present Strength in control Clean, even burn	SYMPTOMS (TOO WET) Muted aroma Dull sweetness Muddy flavours Sluggish / uneven burn Weak finish
ROOT CAUSE Excessive combustion temperature Aromatics destroyed before proper release.	ROOT CAUSE Temperature, water activity, and volatile release are aligned within the optimal window.	ROOT CAUSE Incomplete pyrolysis Volatile release suppressed Flavour development limited.

Cigars passing through peak may taste inconsistent or improve mid-smoke.
 Diagnosis requires leaf-level measurement, not assumptions.

Customer complaint: “This cigar feels harsh and overly peppery.”

- Professional diagnosis: possible under-humidification or below-peak RH performance.
- The cigar may be combusting too aggressively.
- Recommended action: re-equilibrate the cigar, reduce combustion aggression and restore moisture balance.
- Do not automatically assume the blend is “too strong.”

The symptom is evidence; the cause must be diagnosed.



Scenario 2 – Flat Flavour

Smoothness can signal excess moisture

Customer complaint: “The cigar feels smooth, but there is very little flavour.”

TOO DRY (BELOW PEAK)	PEAK FLAVOUR (OPTIMAL)	TOO WET (ABOVE PEAK)
SYMPTOMS (TOO DRY)	AT PEAK (OPTIMAL)	SYMPTOMS (TOO WET)
- Sharp pepper - Bitterness - Hot burn - Nicotine spike - Sweetness collapses	- Aromas expressive - Sweetness balanced - Body present - Strength in control - Clean, even burn	- Muted aroma - Dull sweetness - Muddy flavours - Sluggish / uneven burn - Weak finish
ROOT CAUSE	ROOT CAUSE	ROOT CAUSE
Excessive combustion temperature Aromatics destroyed before proper release.	Temperature, water activity, and volatile release are aligned within the optimal window.	Incomplete pyrolysis Volatile release suppressed Flavour development limited.
Q <i>Cigars passing through peak may taste inconsistent or improve mid-smoke. Diagnosis requires leaf-level measurement, not assumptions.</i>		

- Professional diagnosis: possible over-humidification or above-peak RH performance.
- The cigar may be combusting too coolly and inefficiently.
- Recommended action: stage into a lower RH range, improve combustion efficiency and restore flavour release.
- Do not mistake muted softness for true peak performance.

Flat flavour often means incomplete volatile release.



Scenario 3 – Inconsistent Performance

Two cigars from the same box can smoke differently

Customer complaint: “Two cigars from the same box smoked differently.”

TOO DRY (BELOW PEAK)	PEAK FLAVOUR (OPTIMAL)	TOO WET (ABOVE PEAK)
SYMPTOMS (TOO DRY) 🔥 Sharp pepper 🌿 Bitterness 🔥 Hot burn 🚬 Nicotine spike 📉 Sweetness collapses	AT PEAK (OPTIMAL) ✅ Aromas expressive ✅ Sweetness balanced ✅ Body present ✅ Strength in control ✅ Clean, even burn	SYMPTOMS (TOO WET) 🌫️ Muted aroma 🌫️ Dull sweetness 🌫️ Muddy flavours 🐢 Sluggish / uneven burn 📉 Weak finish
ROOT CAUSE Excessive combustion temperature Aromatics destroyed before proper release.	ROOT CAUSE Temperature, water activity, and volatile release are aligned within the optimal window.	ROOT CAUSE Incomplete pyrolysis Volatile release suppressed Flavour development limited.
🔍 <i>Cigars passing through peak may taste inconsistent or improve mid-smoke. Diagnosis requires leaf-level measurement, not assumptions.</i>		

- Professional diagnosis: possible unequal equilibration or RH drift.
- Wrapper and filler may not have stabilized at the same speed.
- Recommended action: stabilize storage conditions, verify equalization and reassess smoking readiness.
- The problem may be timing and conditioning rather than product inconsistency.

Consistency requires controlled storage and verified readiness.



Examination Alignment

What candidates should be able to explain and defend

CORE EXPLANATIONS

- Define Peak-Flavour RH accurately.
- Explain why peak flavour exists.
- Distinguish flavour balance from strength.
- Explain why small RH changes matter.

CORE DIAGNOSIS

- Predict RH-related failure modes.
- Apply the framework diagnostically.
- Avoid brand-based assumptions.
- Remain observational, combustion-based and causal.

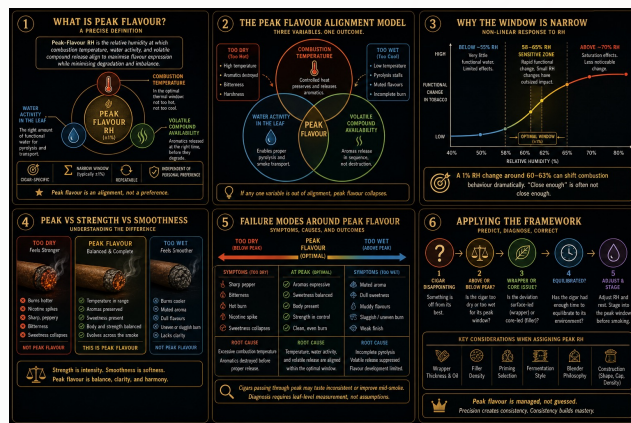
Candidates are expected to explain why the cigar is performing correctly or incorrectly.



Core Professional Principles

Statements candidates should defend orally

Module 3 operating principles



- Peak flavour is a combustion and moisture alignment condition.
- Flavour deteriorates differently above and below peak RH.
- Strength, smoothness and aroma do not automatically indicate peak performance.
- Small RH changes can significantly affect flavour delivery.
- Proper cigar performance can be predicted through combustion and moisture understanding.

These statements form the operating language of Module 3.



The Final Principle of Module 3

Peak-Flavor science turns cigar evaluation into a controllable system



- A cigar can be expensive, strong, smooth or aromatic and still perform outside its ideal flavour condition.
- The professional sommelier moves from “This cigar tastes good” to “This cigar is performing correctly — and I can explain why.”
- Peak flavour is managed deliberately through RH, water activity, combustion temperature, volatile release, equilibration and service preparation.

Peak flavour is an alignment, not a preference.

